

Ryan Carmody

1st Reflection Assignment

I believe my identity is a story that could be described as a small-town boy meeting the big city. Even if describing St. Louis as the “big city” is a bit of a stretch. I grew up a mostly sheltered life without knowing my life was sheltered. My parents were traditional as my mother would come from Georgia where my grandfather worked in banking while my father would come from Illinois where my other Grandfather would be a long-standing judge. I was brought up Catholic where I would attend certain schools, religious curriculum, and mass weekly. My religion affected my identity greatly as I was bound to the commandments which I was taught to follow. For example, one vivid memory I have was hiding my report card from my parents when I was in the third grade. Due to the expectations my parents held for me and my siblings academically, I was determined to not let them find out my shortcomings in the classroom. However, they found out I was hiding my grades and punished me as they considered it a form of lying. Although it was, I was sent to confession. Where I was led to believe the stakes were I could either confess what I had done or be bound to an eternity in hell for breaking a commandment. I have thought about this over the years as I question how someone could claim that a fitting punishment for my lie would be an eternity burning.

Growing up, my biggest dream was to attend the University of Notre Dame like my father before me and many generations before him. Notre Dame was the biggest dream I have ever had and was even baptized on the campus. However, I would not get into the University and let it define me for some time as the moment I had been waiting for since I was able to walk had come and gone with nothing to show for it. The pandemic had come into full effect just after I received the news and I fell into a state of depression. I was lost like never before because of a

decision that a few people made who had never met me or had the slightest idea of who I was. However, I eventually overcame this and became comfortable at Saint Louis University. It's impossible to say that Notre Dame holds no weight towards my identity as throughout my life it has meant so much to me.

Growing up in Georgia with traditional parents, I really had little to no experience with Gender identity and the concept of what creates who we are. I knew no one who was different from societal expectations even in 2019 as every friend I had or anyone I had known was straight, identified with the gender they were born with, and were fairly closed minded to other concepts. My school and town were primarily white, and most kids were either brought up on a golf course or through agriculture. I had known of the overwhelming wave of progressiveness that was sweeping across the country as many had politicized it, especially from the south. Claiming the left was poisoning children with this gender revolution and the defund the Police movement. I, however, really had no thoughts on the issue and paid no attention to any political matter as most teenagers wouldn't. When I began attending Saint Louis University, I underwent a state of shock as I was exposed to ideals and culture I had never known. My first weeks at Reinert Hall included constant police sirens coming down Grand or walking to class only to pass Circle-K where the homeless would find shelter outside the store. All in all, the learning curve was difficult to live every day in this setting that was so different from where I was used to. However, overcoming my comfort zone and embracing the city of St. Louis has helped me grow as a human and grew my understanding of others.

My sister and I were born close to a year apart with my birthday being October of 2001 and hers May of 2003. Meaning we grew up together with a very close relationship, attending the same preschool, going to the same birthday parties, and being each other's friend. Every morning

our mother would wake hours before anyone else to pick our outfits for the day and make us breakfast before we would go to school. My sister would usually wear a blouse, or a dress and I would always wear a polo shirt and shorts in warmer weather and a jacket with pants in colder weather. It was always crucial to my mom that we dressed very well and made an impression. One day after school, my sister and I were playing as we did every day at that age. However, this time, we would be playing dress up with switched roles. As I would dress my sister in my clothes while she did my make-up and put me in a dress. I remember my mom being very upset at this and immediately made us change our outfits and took off the makeup I had on. Both of us were put in timeout and never tried anything such as that again.

I believe my above example satisfies what the reflection is asking as I truly cannot recall memories where I would have my enlightenment towards my gender identity. I was put in sports at a young age where I would be taught masculinity and what is expected to be a “man”. My parents were very traditional Catholics in which they controlled much of my siblings and my own childhood. Since I have gotten to Saint Louis University, I have begun enlightenment on many fronts such as political, spiritual, and emotional identities. I believe my two experiences interrelate as I question what chance someone who grows up in a strict religious household has in finding their identity. I don’t know how my relationship with my parents would look had I identified as anything other than male. Those who have the opportunity to explore their identity and identify as anything other than what their birth certificate states, I imagine are met with great backlash or consequences. I am sorry that this is the case today but hope that one day we can accept everyone for how they identify themselves.